

Recognize it

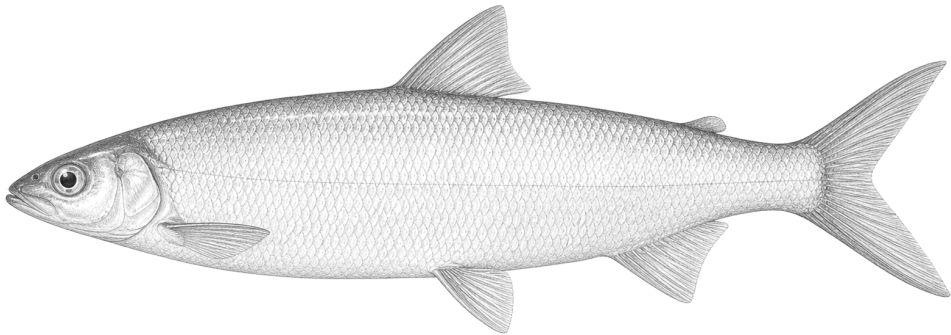
Slender silver fish with large scales, forked tail, and a small adipose fin between dorsal and tail.

Body	Laterally compressed; lower jaw often reaches or projects beyond upper jaw.
Mouth/fins	Small terminal mouth; soft-rayed fins; no spines.
Confusion	Whitefish has a more strongly overhanging snout; shad lacks the adipose fin.

Lake role

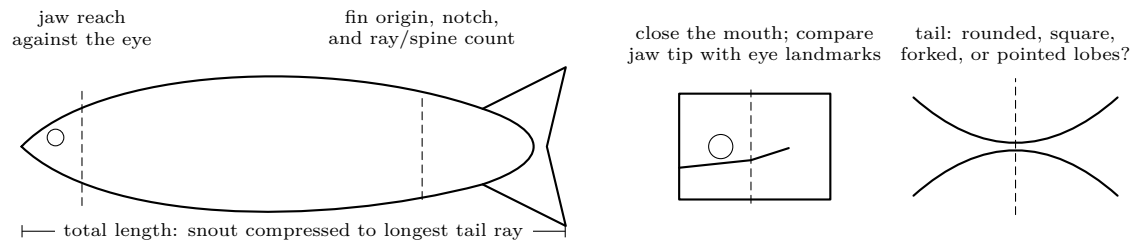
Where it belongs
Deep, cool, oxygenated open water; schools track zooplankton.
Food and season
Mostly plankton and small invertebrates; depth changes with temperature and light.

Identification plate



Original graphite portrait for this ChatGPT edition. Morphology reviewed against Wisconsin DNR species references.

Read the fish before naming it



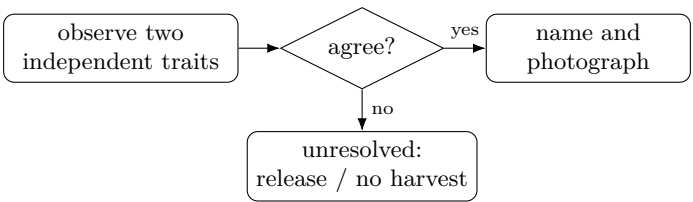
- 1. **Silhouette first.** Confirm a slender silver body, deeply forked tail, and large easily shed scales.
- 2. **Hard structure second.** Find the small adipose fin between the soft dorsal and tail; verify that no fin has spines.
- 3. **Markings last.** Check whether the lower jaw reaches or projects beyond the upper jaw.

Intermediate questions

Before looking at the species name, answer aloud: *Where does the closed jaw end? Are dorsal sections joined or separate? What is the tail-lobe shape? Which mark is structural enough to survive poor light?* If two answers conflict, record “unresolved” and do not force the identification.

Confusion-pair gate

Candidate	Cisco
Nearest alternative	Whitefish has a more strongly overhanging snout; shad lacks the adipose fin.
Required gate	Do not call cisco without an adipose fin plus the terminal/upturned jaw profile.
Independent check	Photograph dorsal-to-tail spacing and closed-jaw profile before rapid release or icing.



Find it on these waters

Pine	Historical-only evidence places cisco here; the current broad DNR record does not. Do not target until current evidence confirms a suspended school.
North Evidence	Not named by the current broad DNR fish record; do not assume presence without survey evidence. The DNR lake records sometimes name only a broad group such as panfish. In that case this species is a candidate member, not verified individual presence. Confirm presence before targeting; treat locations as testable habitat hypotheses, not abundance findings.

Field evidence log

Date/time	Water + station	Depth/temp	Two observed traits	Habitat, lure, result
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Evidence threshold. One sighting is an observation, not an abundance claim. Repeat the same identification gate on another fish, retain a clear lateral photograph when lawful and safe, and note failed searches as carefully as catches. Only repeated suspended marks plus a verified fish update the historical-presence hypothesis.

Presentations

1. **Fine vertical jig.** Place a tiny spoon or fly at the marked depth with light line.
2. **Ice flasher approach.** Drill a search grid only on verified safe ice and follow suspended marks.
3. **Stop rule.** No verified school means no cisco pattern; switch species rather than fishing an unsupported story.

On-water verification

After the first response, ask: *Did the fish, depth, cover, and bite match the prediction?* Repeat once. If the second result disagrees, return to search mode rather than explaining away the evidence.

HANDLING DECIDES THE OUTCOME

Cold-water fish warm quickly. Unhook in the net, minimize air, and return promptly unless lawfully retained.

Harvest decision · 2026–27

Water-specific rule	Open all year; no minimum; cisco/whitefish daily bag 10 on both lake rule pages, checked 2026-07-26.
Kitchen choice	Keep only bright, firm fish that can be iced immediately; smaller adults generally cook more evenly.
Before the trip	Open the Wisconsin DNR water-specific regulation page for WBIC 779200 (Pine) or 850800 (North). Check the exact water, species, and date; the live rule controls if this dated sheet differs.

Keep only a fish you can use

Decide before the cast. Bring ice, stop fishing when the planned meal is secured, and use the species-specific cooking guide for dispatch, bone layout, and safe preparation. Large old predators are valuable spawners and generally carry more mercury than smaller fish.

Sources checked 2026-07-26. Wisconsin DNR lake fish records (Pine WBIC 779200; North WBIC 850800), Wisconsin's Fishes, Hook Your Catch, 2026–27 water-specific regulations, Catch-and-release Guidelines, and Eating Your Catch. Biological and tactical synthesis is editorial; it is not a current population survey.

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